CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

POOL TECHNICIAN IN THE AI ERA

In pool country, a green pool by Friday is a five-alarm emergency — and a clean route of backyards pays like clockwork all summer.

★ **TL;DR — Median around $45K for route techs, enterable in 1–6 months with no license required in most places for cleaning and maintenance. The catch: routes are seasonal in cold states, and the step from cleaner to repair-tech is where pay actually moves.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

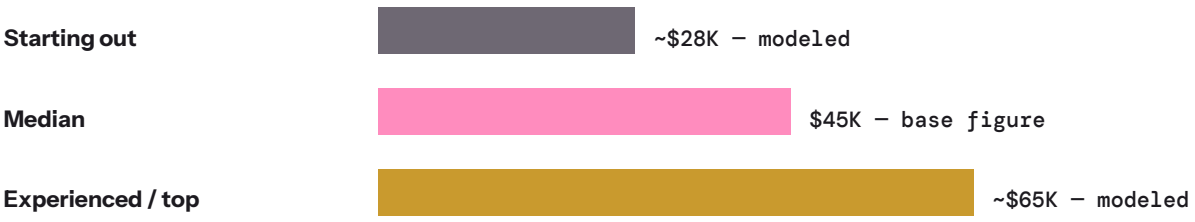
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Works because: pools need weekly chemistry and cleaning without exception, owners pay for never thinking about it, and routes repeat forever.
- Bites because: it's a route business — missed stops and green pools destroy trust (and accounts) fast.
- AI angle: minimal. Sensors test water and apps log visits; brushing, vacuuming, filter work and equipment repair are hands in the sun.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Pool Technician is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A POOL TECHNICIAN ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Run a weekly route: test and balance water chemistry, brush, vacuum, skim, empty baskets
- ✓ Clean and service filters, pumps, heaters and salt systems; spot failing equipment early
- ✓ Rescue green pools: shock, brush, filter cycles and follow-ups until they clear
- ✓ Document visits with photos and notes — proof of service is the product owners actually buy

Think: a lifeguard for water chemistry — nobody drowns on your watch except algae, and it tries to, weekly.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Robotic cleaners scrub floors and smart sensors watch chemistry between visits. They assist routes; they don't repair a pump, rebuild a filter, or talk an owner through a green-pool rescue.	Diagnosis by eye and test kit, equipment judgment (repair or replace?), and route trust — you're alone in people's backyards weekly, which is why reliable techs keep accounts for years.

⚠ **Some states and counties DO require certification for commercial/public pool service, and commercial pools carry health-code rules — check your market. Also, chemical handling (chlorine, acid) is a real safety discipline, not a footnote.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Outdoors, independent, music-in-one-ear route life ✓ Predictable recurring accounts — the route is an annuity ✓ A famously buyable business: routes get bought and sold like assets	✗ Peak summer is brutal: heat, sun and maximum route loads ✗ Cold climates compress income into a season ✗ One green pool photo on social media can cost you a street

Good fit? You're self-managing, detail-steady and honest to a fault — the job is unsupervised trust plus chemistry discipline.
Bad fit? You need winters busy in a cold state, or you're casual about routines. Pools punish casual within two weeks, visibly.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — ROUTE TECH AT A POOL COMPANY	DOOR B — BUY OR BUILD YOUR OWN ROUTE

Pool service companies hire and train route techs constantly in pool markets: chemistry, cleaning standards, and equipment basics on real routes. In 1–6 months you can own a route — and your retention numbers become your reputation.	Start your own service: a vehicle, testing kit, chemicals and your first accounts from neighbors and real-estate referrals. Routes are also literally sold in this industry — buying a small route is a known shortcut into ownership.

Smart move: Climb from cleaning into repair: pumps, heaters, automation and leak detection pay multiples of cleaning rates and make you the company owners can't lose. CPO certification (for commercial pools) opens hotels, HOAs and gyms — contract money.
Where you land after: Route tech → repair tech → route owner or service manager; owners scale by adding routes and techs.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN WATER	GET ON	MASTER THE	HANDLE THE	MOVE INTO	OWN ROUTES

STEP 1 — Learn water chemistry properly

FREE-LOW · WEEKS

- Chlorine, pH, alkalinity, CYA, calcium — and how they push on each other. This is the science core of the trade.
- Practice on any pool you can access until test-and-dose is automatic.

STEP 2 — Get on a route

1-6 MO BAND

- Apply to pool companies, or line up your first solo accounts if you're going independent.
- Learn the standard: brush, vacuum, baskets, tile line, equipment check — same quality, unsupervised.

STEP 3 — Master the equipment pad

MONTHS 2-6

- Pumps, filters (sand, cartridge, DE), heaters, salt cells, cleaners — clean, service, spot failure.
- Photo-document every visit; owners and managers both buy proof.

STEP 4 — Handle the green rescues

ONGOING

- Algae remediation is the trade's exam under pressure: chemistry, brushing, filtration, patience.
- A cleared green pool, documented, is the best advertisement that exists.

STEP 5 — Move into repair work

MONTHS 4+

- Pump and motor swaps, heater basics, automation controls, leak detection.
- Get CPO certified if commercial accounts (hotels, HOAs, public pools) are in your market — some jurisdictions require it for public pools.

STEP 6 — Own routes

YEAR 1+

- Buy or build routes until they cover a full week; routes are sellable assets in this industry.
- Add a second tech and become the standard they work to — that's the company version.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: list pool companies hiring techs; buy a proper test kit and learn it.
- □ Days 1–30: chemistry fluency and route standards on real pools.
- □ Days 31–60: equipment pad mastery — filters and pumps serviced without supervision.
- □ Days 61–90: first green-pool rescue assisted or owned; CPO course booked if commercial work beckons.
- □ Day 90: a route tech owners trust alone in backyards — the only credential this trade starts with, and it compounds.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ CLEAR WATER. EVERY WEEK. NO EXCUSES. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.